



Douglas County Libraries

James

by Percival Everett

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Discussion Questions

1. *James* is a retelling of Mark Twain's 1885 novel *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*, which is widely regarded as a classic work of American literature. Have you read *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn* before? How does Everett subvert Twain's original text? Did this reimagination change your perspective on the original novel?
2. Twain is well-known for his satirical writing. Where does Everett use humor and satire in *James*? What social and cultural conditions does the novel's satire mock or critique?
3. Reflect on Jim's narration. Why does he switch between vernacular and standardized English? How did this code-switching affect your reading experience?
4. Describe Huck's role in the story. How does Jim's fugitive status, as well as race, color, class, age, and education, influence the relationship between the two characters?
5. *James* depicts the brutalities of slavery, particularly the violence inflicted upon enslaved women and girls, through the stories of Sadie, Lizzie, Sammy, and Katie. What are the unique threats that these characters must navigate? How does Jim react to the gendered violence that he encounters?
6. Return to Jim's travels with the minstrel group. What does the novel say about the performance of race? How do blackface minstrelsy and racial passing complicate or undermine racial classification? Can all the characters be seen as performers of race?
7. Jim's quest for freedom parallels his quest for literacy. Discuss the key moments on his journey to writing his story. What are the texts that he studies? Who are the characters who give him the tools and encouragement to write?
8. *James* references author William Wells Browning, composer Daniel Decatur Emmett, and philosophers John Locke, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, and Voltaire. Consider researching these figures. How do they influence your understanding of the historical period?
9. Discuss the use of religion and superstition in the story.
10. Were you surprised by Jim's revelation in chapter one of part three? Returning to earlier passages, can you identify any moments of foreshadowing from Everett? How would you characterize Huck's reaction? Have you ever learned something shocking about your family's history?

11. *James* features an ensemble of fugitive and enslaved characters. How does Everett affirm the humanity of these characters in his writing? Was there one who was particularly memorable to you?
12. The Mississippi River is central to the landscape of the novel. What is the role of the river? How did it shape the political landscape of the region and the events of the novel?
13. Reflect on the title, *James*. What's the significance of Jim renaming himself? Why do you think Everett chose to title the novel in this way?
14. What was your reaction to the novel's ending? What do you think the future holds for James and his family?
15. After reading *James*, can you think of another character from a classic text that you would like to read as the narrator of their own story?

Author Interview

This spring, Percival Everett spoke with Dan White, Humanities Writer at UC Santa Cruz, about the creation of his 2024 National Book Award-winning novel *James*, a book that reoccupies and reimagines Mark Twain's *Huckleberry Finn* from the perspective of the enslaved character Jim.

James is this year's UC Santa Cruz Deep Read book. The Deep Read is a free public program at The Humanities Institute that creates a reading community around an award-winning book. The program includes an email series, a course, virtual and in-person discussions about the book with faculty members from different disciplines, and a culminating event with the author in Santa Cruz. On May 4, Everett will be in conversation with Deep Read Faculty Co-Lead and Professor of Literature Vilashini Cooppan at the Quarry Amphitheater.

In anticipation of his visit to UC Santa Cruz, Everett talked with White about his writing. During a wide-ranging, informal talk, Everett delved into his ongoing conversation with the works of long-dead authors, his adventures as a screenwriter, and why he refuses to write novels with obvious take-away messages for the reader.

DW: Where am I reaching you from?

PE: I'm in my studio. My painting studio is a few blocks away. This is where I write, but mainly I repair guitars and mandolins. This is where I do that... I started doing it during COVID because I could find broken guitars for 18 dollars and end up having a nice Gibson L or something. And then all of a sudden, I had too many guitars, and other people started discovering this hobby, and now broken guitars cost 200, 300 dollars plus. (laughs.)

DW: Kind of reminds me of Daniel Day-Lewis taking a year off to cobble shoes.

PE: Well, that sounds like a great idea. A new hobby for me.

DW: And I read somewhere that you train horses. Surely all these experiences make their way into your art in some way.

PE: I don't train horses now. Now I am just trained by my two dogs. But I think everything I learn from making art comes from animals.

DW: Yes. Animals have such a powerful sense of presence. They live in an eternal now.

PE: A horse has never lied to me.

DW: In a couple of interviews, you've mentioned being in conversation with Mark Twain while writing *James*. From a craft perspective, what does that actually mean? What does it feel like to engage in a dialogue with another writer—especially one from a different time—while you're in the process of creating your own work?

PE: First of all, I am very lucky that I get to participate in this ongoing discourse that is, well, I hesitate to say storytelling but constructing meaning, even though as a writer I don't get to make any of it but I get to present it so meaning can be made from the product. I was one of Kurt Vonnegut's army of 14-year-olds when I was a kid. You know, I couldn't wait for his new books to come out. Even though I don't write anything like Vonnegut, I can see his influence on me and the way he responded to the world and saw the world and the generosity of spirit that he seemed to always exhibit regarding art. That not only influences me but keeps me writing and thinking about those things as I do it—or I should say when I'm away from it—because I don't think of anything when I'm writing. I don't know if that made any sense at all.

DW: Well, that makes a lot of sense because writing is such a private act for you. You shut the world out.

PE: Well, I don't like messages so I abandon all allegiance to my own beliefs knowing that I can't escape them. My politics will be there but if I think about politics when I am writing I am doomed to write a message novel and I am not interested in doing that.

DW: So these themes kind of appear organically in your work – or is it that you can't keep them out?

PE: We can't keep them out. The things that are important to us will show up. Mainly, I always have some very abstract and logical or even arithmetical axiom or idea at the bottom of my work that I am trying to work out that I don't expect any reader to see, and in exploring that I start trying to find stories that will allow me to think about that in different ways and the stories are—often there is no way to connect them but they connect for me.

DW: Did writing *James*—which in many ways is a very straightforward story—feel different to you from writing some of the other novels where the philosophy is more front and center, and in which the reading experience is more challenging—an enjoyable thicket for the reader to push through? I'm thinking of books like *Dr. No* and *Glyph*, for instance.

PE: Certainly it was, in that I was dealing with an extant text, and also the research was different. My research for writing *James* was more or less forgetting another text, not exploring it. I tried to create a blur. I didn't want to remember any of the words that Twain used but I wanted to remember the world, so when I finished my exercise of finding a way to hate it, I closed *Huck Finn* and still have never looked at it since I started writing *James*. And anything that is in *James* comes from my memory of that world, not from any appeal to the text.

DW: I'd heard that you read *Huck Finn* many times in preparation for this ...

PE: Yeah, just so I could really get sick of it. You know how when you say a word over and over and it starts to feel weird and lose meaning? It was the same thing—after the tenth reading, it was just nonsense.

DW: But now there is a tremendous amount of public fascination with *Huckleberry Finn*—a newly rekindled discussion because of the success of *James*. And I know you like to move on to the next thing, to move on to the next work instead of dwelling on anything you've written before. Has that been a challenge for you, to linger on *James* for this long?

PE: Well, I still work. It is just a matter of compartmentalizing. It is great that people have this interest in this book, but my interest in it was gone as soon as I finished. People will point out things that I never thought of, which is why I'm writing in the first place... but I am thoroughly sick of James.

DW: I figured you might be, but I bet you're getting contacted by much younger readers now—by high school students, perhaps for the first time.

PE: Certainly I am. My other works are—I don't think people discover them until later anyway. But this one is more accessible for everyone. (But) the increase in mail has actually come from white people over 60 and 70. Every day. And they identify themselves: "I am a white woman. Eighty years old!" Things like that. Just tons of that kind of mail. It is interesting. It is very sweet. You know, I would be excited if any book were getting this kind of attention—a literary novel. It is great that it happens to be mine, it is wonderful, but I am just encouraged by the fact that a novel is getting this kind of attention. That is thrilling to me. I would feel really positive if anyone's book was getting that kind of attention. I just happened to wander into this kind of attention. I'm not sure if it's deserved or whether that even needs to be part of the discussion, but it's a nice thing.

DW: You're also in this highly public event—the Deep Read at UC Santa Cruz—and soon you'll face a whole amphitheater full of people who have been reading along. You talk a lot about writing being a deeply private and subversive thing—you can't really keep your reader in mind when you work—so what is it like to be involved in a program in which you will see 2,000 of your closest readers right in front of you in a big amphitheater?

PE: It's fun. People see stuff I don't see. And I always confess that I suffer from work amnesia—people will bring up scenes that I don't remember. I'll have to do some work in my head to get back there. But that is not a bad problem to have. I feel pretty fortunate about that.

DW: Do you ever look back on your large body of work—where they are all so different—and think about how the books interconnect? How is it that you came to write *James* at this juncture of your career? Is it perhaps something you could not have written before? Do you think about where it exists in the pantheon—could you not have written it before?

PE: I see all the works as in conversation with—except for my first novel (*Suder*, 1983). I don't know how to fit that into a larger conversation. And it takes me a few books to work through different ideas. But if I had written *James* ten years ago, obviously it would've been a different novel. Who knows.

DW: You've written so many different kinds of books. Your works seem to come from different aspects of your creative persona. If I was your agent or publisher, I would be begging for *James* the sequel after the huge success of this. Does it make you want to run the other way and write something else, like *Glyph*? Or how does it impact you?

PE: The attention doesn't affect me at all. Again, it's nice. It's like one day finally I might wear a shirt that everybody likes and it's: "Hey, nice shirt." And then it's in the wash.

DW. And there's nothing you can do once it's in that washing machine.

PE: Yes. Nothing you can do about it. I write because I am interested in different things in the world. I've never written something hoping that it would "hit" or be popular. And the same is true with the novel that's following this one. It is something else. It's something different. And now, as I'm older—for the first time in the last few years (when I've already been old for a while now)—it has dawned on me that I have a limited amount of time to make the books I might like to make. So it's even more crucial for me now that I choose things that are artistically and philosophically interesting to me—and not go on any kind of success.

DW: Could you talk a little bit about your work in progress?

PE: No. I generally don't talk about it... it's a novel. But you probably could have guessed that. As I always say — if I could encapsulate it, I would have written a pamphlet, not a novel.

DW: Any challenge you still want to take on? In the past you've talked about your desire to write a purely abstract novel.

PE: Well, I am always trying to make things shorter. I am still trying to make an abstract work. The difficulty for writers is that the constituent parts of our art are representational. Unlike a note of music or paint, they necessarily tie to concepts and things in the world. So the idea of making that abstract is confusing in itself. I think I should be able to do it. I've never seen it. I don't know what it would look like. I may not even know if I've achieved it—if I ever do it—because someone else could say that. "Oh, he managed to do it before that bus hit him." It's always in my head. And novels take different shapes.

DW: You're also a mentor, a teacher. You teach grad students one-on-one, and you teach undergrads. How do you run your classes?

PE: I actually prefer teaching undergrads. They are more adventurous than grad students. My job with graduate students is to disabuse them of the idea that there is a correct way to make a novel—to get them out of whatever rut they've found themselves in, just trying to do something "right." And I find undergraduates are a lot more open. And often, the work is not as good—not as polished—but it can be a lot more fun. I don't think there is an interesting work in the world that is not a failed path. That is often what's interesting—fascinating—about literature: when does a story fail? And that's not a bad thing.

DW: So you are saying successful work will originate from something that was originally considered a failure?

PE: No. I think all great novels fail in some way. And that is what makes them interesting. The *Adventures of Huckleberry Finn*—it's not a very good novel when you get right down to it—but it's really important for a number of good reasons. So art's an interesting thing. I read everything because I often learn from stuff I wouldn't normally read or that I don't even like.

DW: How does *Huckleberry Finn* fail?

PE: Twain abandoned the work for several years in the middle, and you can almost see the demarcation—the language changes, the movement of the novel changes. He abandons Huck's moral dilemma to some extent to move on to an adventure with the reassertion of Tom Sawyer. And that's sad to say—and I try to find ways to reason where it's not the case—it is a mercenary move on his part to reintroduce this moneymaking character, Tom Sawyer, Twain having been quite famously in debt all the time. So it *does* fall apart—

and because of the character I actually hate: it's Tom Sawyer.

I did find a way to read it more generously, I guess you could say—with more generosity to Twain—and that is: Twain, being a decent person in many ways (I'll say something else about that in a second), did not like the way Reconstruction had affected the South, and particularly newly freed slaves. And one of the things that Tom and Huck are doing is using Jim as a pawn in a game—very much as newly freed Black people were in the North and South. And that could be—even if it's unconscious—and it doesn't matter what he *meant*—but that's a way of reading the text in a more generous way.

There's a woman, Kerry Driscoll, who wrote a fantastic book (*Mark Twain Among The Indians And Other Indigenous Peoples*) about Twain's treatment of Native people in his writing. And you come away from it not feeling terribly positive about Twain. He really hated—he was a bigot when it came to Native people. And I came to that just recently. So I am reassessing my reevaluation of Twain vis-a-vis African Americans as well. That's just how he was in the world.

I, of course, am trying to be respectful of the fact that I am benefiting from 140 more years of human so-called evolution. But I'm wondering: if you can't see your racism towards anyone and then own up to the fact that you can behave in a racist way—then you can never honestly address it. So I am wondering—being a product of his time—much of his attitude towards Black people was paternal, which was, at its root, racist. Which is why Locke, Rousseau, and Voltaire are present in the novel.

DW: Speaking of Huckleberry Finn's shortcomings—some of the issues that Twain kind of elided in the text—such as the fatherly role of James to Huck—you dove right in. How soon in the composition process did you know how much of a father figure that James would be to Huck? Did you know from the beginning?

PE: Yes. It's present in Twain's world also. But it is complicated by the fact that Twain's depiction of Jim is so stereotypic—superstitious, simple-minded, and not subject to second-order thinking that might make him a more interesting character. But it occurred to me almost immediately—because it *is* there.

DW: Your fleshing-out of James as a father figure has been the subject of a broad conversation—and there's also a fascination with way your book dramatizes this kind of code-switching, in which James will speak one way to other enslaved people and in a much different way to the white characters ...

PE: Everyone wants to call that code-switching—I just call it being human. If you are surviving, language is the first survival skill we learn. And to give it a cool-sounding name (laughs) I think sometimes misses the point—that it is simply what we *do*. I am not going to start calling eating a “nutrition injection.”

DW: Well, it just feels like survival mode. James had to keep his learning and reading completely private. As you mention—as you say—the act of learning how to read could get you killed.

PE: Yeah. Apparently it still can.

DW: How so?

PE: Are you familiar with a state called Florida? (laughs.)

DW: Speaking of Florida, you've been very outspoken about book bans as performative acts—and attempts to censor literature.

PE: It is an act of fascists. That is the first thing fascists do—go after books and art—because that is where we are most human. Our consumption of those things. And it is not writing that I consider so wonderfully subversive. It is actually reading, the most subversive thing we can do. The second most subversive thing you can do is not writing. It is being part of a book club because you are really keeping art alive and talking about ideas and that is fantastic.

DW: So I suppose, in that context, The Humanities Institute's Deep Read program must be incredibly subversive, considering that it's like a gigantic book club.

PE: It is terrific. I go out and do these things now and speak to a bunch of people and I point out to them that we all think alike in that we love literature, but, in the mad scheme of things, this is not a very large group. My publisher sells 50,000 books, they'd be thrilled. But if I sold 50,000 records, I'd never record again! So we're not a reading culture. We have to keep that in perspective. I wish we were more of one.

DW: Yes, and I just read that we are reading fewer books than ever before in US history.

PE: Which is crazy since there are so many more of us—because they are not making that figure per capita. (laughs)

DW: I just can't understand why reading is not an intrinsic value for everyone.

PE: If I can write a novel that challenges TikTok, maybe we have a chance.

DW: And that poses a real challenge for you and all literary artists. In an age where people aren't reading very much, is it still possible that art can make people better human beings, and lead to a better society?

PE: If I didn't have that reason, I wouldn't be making art at all. I truly hope that it's possible—Walt Whitman in *(By Blue Ontario's Shores)* said, and I paraphrase: if you want a better society, produce better people. And when I say art, I have an expansive idea of art. It is not just literature, it is not just painting and music. Scholarship is art. Journalism is art. These are things that affect us, and we should go at them with the understanding that we are creating our culture. That said—Picasso's painting *Guernica* changed the world. But when you think about it, very few people have ever seen it.

DW: And you are a painter yourself. As with your novels, you are in complete control when you're working on a canvas. But now you're attached to write the screenplay for the movie version of *James*, making you part of a larger process, a bigger machine in which you're just one component. What's that like for you?

PE: Writing a screenplay is a very new experience. I'd have to get back to you on that. But so far, I've enjoyed the process. I'm talking to smart people and handing in work I don't feel an attachment to. I want to make it a special work, but it's not the same as *making a* novel, and I have no proprietary feelings

about a film in the same way I would about a novel, because I understand it is a collaborative work. And I am not a filmmaker. I don't have a vision of it. That's for other people to come up with. And I'll try to do my part in this, but it may well look very different from anything I've imagined, and I'm completely open to that.

DW: Because in a sense, you've already been through that with *Erasure*, which was adapted into a film, *American Fiction*. They had their vision.

PE: And I had nothing to do with the making of that film, except for just making some good friends. And I really liked the work. Even if I hadn't, it's an exciting thing to see a brand-new work of art generated by something that you've made.

Biography

PERCIVAL EVERETT is a Distinguished Professor of English at USC. His most recent books include *Dr. No* (finalist for the NBCC Award for Fiction and winner of the PEN/ Jean Stein Book Award), *The Trees* (finalist for the Booker Prize and the PEN/Faulkner Award for Fiction), *Telephone* (finalist for the Pulitzer Prize), *So Much Blue*, *Erasure*, and *I Am Not Sidney Poitier*. He has received the NBCC Ivan Sandrof Life Achievement Award, The Windham Campbell Prize from Yale University, and the Stowe Prize for Literary Activism. *American Fiction*, the feature film based on his novel *Erasure*, was released in 2023 and was awarded the Academy Award for Best Adapted Screenplay. He lives in Los Angeles with his wife, the writer Danzy Senna, and their children.

<https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com/authors/2012542/percival-everett/>

‘Huck Finn’ Is a Masterpiece. This Retelling Just Might Be, Too.

“James” takes Mark Twain’s classic tale and places the enslaved sidekick, Jim, at its center.

by Dwight Garner

“Adventures of Huckleberry Finn,” the critic Lionel Trilling wrote, is “one of the world’s great books and one of the central documents of American culture,” in part because it grows with its readers. Mark Twain’s 1884 novel is a catapulting adventure story when one is 10, but its amplitude is grasped only in adulthood.

Here is a question Trilling did not pick up: What about the 10-year-old Black reader who wishes to be catapulted, too, but is too young to understand that the novel’s language, with its 219 uses of the N-word, derives from Twain’s writerly fidelity to the vernacular speech of the American South in the 1830s or 1840s, when the novel is set? This has long been an implacable and racking issue.

Paul Beatty, in his novel “The Sellout” (2015), wrestled with this conundrum. One of his characters decides to read “Huckleberry Finn” aloud to his grandchildren. He does not get far. Then he gets an idea.

Although they are the deepest-thinking, combat-ready 8- and 10-year-olds I know, I knew my babies weren’t ready to comprehend “Huckleberry Finn” on its own merits. That’s why I took the liberty to rewrite Mark Twain’s masterpiece. Where the repugnant “N-word” occurs, I replaced it with “warrior” and the word “slave” with “dark-skinned volunteer.”

Percival Everett’s majestic new novel, “James,” goes several steps further. Everett flips the perspective on the events in “Huckleberry Finn.” He gives us the story as a coolly electric first-person narrative in the voice of Jim, the novel’s enslaved runaway. The pair’s adventures on the raft as it twisted down the Mississippi River were largely, from Huck’s perspective, larks. From Jim’s — excuse me, James’s — point of view, nearly every second is deadly serious. We recall that Jim told Huck, in Twain’s novel, that he was quite done with “adventures.”

Everett’s James is indeed a warrior, of a humane, frazzled and reluctant sort. By the time this novel is finished, he will have killed men and freed fellow slaves and set fire to a particularly dismal plantation. He will be whispered about, a legend. What’s more, Everett has rendered him an ambitious reader, one who instantly grasps, for example, that the Bible is a tool of his oppressors, and who has extended internal dialogues with Jean-Jacques Rousseau, Voltaire and John Locke, sometimes about slavery. James is literate, and he is taking notes. These notes are costly. Another slave who pilfers a pencil stub for him is lynched for the act.

Because this is a Percival Everett novel, we are not surprised that he tears down and rebuilds a cultural landmark. In addition to his publishing-industry satire “Erasure,” which became the Cord Jefferson film “American Fiction,” this prolific writer has issued novels that take on the complicated legacies of historical figures. These include Sidney Poitier, in “I Am Not Sidney Poitier” (2009), which is one of the funniest novels I have ever read, and the prune-faced South Carolina segregationist Strom Thurmond, in “A History of the African-American People (Proposed) by Strom Thurmond, as Told to Percival Everett and James Kincaid” (2004).

Because this is a Percival Everett novel, too, it luxuriates in language. Everett, like Twain, is a master of American argot; he is the code switcher's code switcher. In "James," he puts his skills to incandescent use. His narrator runs his every public utterance through what he calls his "slave filter," to make himself sound ridiculous and gullible, to pacify the truculent white people around him. Here is that practice in action, as James explains to a group of enslaved children in a cabin, including a girl named February, how to survive:

The children said together, "And the better they feel, the safer we are."

"February, translate that."

"Da mo' betta dey feels, da mo' safer we be."

"Nice."

And here is James, finding himself in Judge Thatcher's library:

I had wondered every time I sneaked in there what white people would do to a slave who had learned how to read. What would they do to a slave who had taught the other slaves to read? What would they do to a slave who knew what a hypotenuse was, what *irony* meant, how *retribution* was spelled?

What sets "James" above Everett's previous novels, as casually and caustically funny as many are, is that here the humanity is turned up — way up. This is Everett's most thrilling novel, but also his most soulful. Beneath the wordplay, and below the packed dirt floor of Everett's moral sensibility, James is an intensely imagined human being. Ta-Nehisi Coates, in "Between the World and Me" (2015), wrote that slavery is not "an indefinable mass of flesh" but "a particular, specific enslaved woman, whose mind is active as your own, whose range of feeling is as vast as your own." Everett more than lives up to that prescription.

He is not scoring easy points. He is evoking and critiquing the American experiment, circa the middle of the 19th century, from a wised-up slave's point of view. Huck talked a lot about feeling lonesome in Twain's novel. Everett's James, at certain moments, seems like the loneliest man who ever lived.

Everett mostly sticks to the broad outlines of Twain's novel. He is riding the same currents; the book flows inexorably, like a river, yet its short chapters keep the movement swift. James is on the run, of course, because he has learned that Miss Watson plans to sell him to a man in New Orleans. He will be separated from his wife and children. Huck is on the run because he has faked his own death after being beaten by his father. They find each other on an island in the Mississippi, and their flight begins. The reader slowly discovers that their bonds run deeper than friendship.

There are familiar large scenes, like Huck and James's separation in a fog, and their encounter with the deadly con artists, the Duke and the King. But smaller moments are reproduced as well, such as James's suffering after a rattlesnake bite and Huck's need to dress like a girl to disguise his identity.

Other scenes drop out, and Everett shifts the setting forward two decades or so, so that we glimpse Union soldiers marching south. New scenes are inserted. I will mention only one, because it is so extraordinary and so deft. At one point James is bought by the Virginia Minstrels, a blackface singing troupe. (They really existed; Twain was a fan.) They need a new tenor, and they've heard him singing for his brutal new owner. Because no Black man can appear on a stage, James must himself put on blackface. The moment is ludicrous and terrifying. The troupe includes 10 white men in blackface, "one Black man passing for white and painted black, and me, a light-brown Black man painted black in such a way as to appear like a white man trying to pass for Black."

In these scenes, Everett makes potent use of the era's songbook. He also delivers this unforgettable moment, when James in disguise is allowed, for the first time, to stare into the eyes of his oppressors:

White people came out and lined the street, smiling and laughing and clapping. I made eye contact with a couple of people in the crowd and the way they looked at me was different from any contact I had ever had with white people. They were open to me, but what I saw, looking into them, was hardly impressive. They sought to share this moment of mocking me, mocking *darkies*, laughing at the poor slaves, with joyful, spirited clapping and stomping.

My idea of hell would be to live with a library that contained only reimaginings of famous novels. It's a wet-brained and dutiful genre, by and large. Or the results are brittle spoofs — to use a word that, according to John Barth, sounds like imperfectly suppressed flatulence — that read as if there are giant scare quotes surrounding the action. Two writers in a hundred walk away unscathed.

"James" is the rarest of exceptions. It should come bundled with Twain's novel. It is a tangled and subversive homage, a labor of rough love. "His humor and humanity affected me long before I became a writer," Everett writes of Twain in his acknowledgments. "Heaven for the climate; hell for my long-awaited lunch with Mark Twain."

Everett does not reprint the famous warning that greets the reader at the start of "Adventures of Huckleberry Finn": "Persons attempting to find a motive in this narrative will be prosecuted; persons attempting to find a moral in it will be banished; persons attempting to find a plot in it will be shot." Motives, morals and plot are here in abundance, of course. And Everett shoots what is certain to be this book's legion of readers straight through the heart.

Dwight Garner has been a book critic for The Times since 2008, and before that was an editor at the Book Review for a decade.

<https://www.nytimes.com/2024/03/11/books/review/percival-everett-james.html>